# YOUTUBE ROCKER



**Prajakta Koli,** *30*
*YouTuber-Actress*

*Photograph by* BANDEEP SINGH

**"I HAVE NEVER BEEN ABLE TO RELATE TO THE WORD** 'influencer'. I've always seen myself as a creator," says the 30-year-old Prajakta Koli as she finishes off her dinner—mac and cheese—at her Mumbai office. Prajakta started her journey eight years ago, regaling people online through her YouTube channel with a host of topics, from parodies and travel vlogs to candid interviews. She has come a long way since then, not only featuring in a Karan Johar film (*Jugg Jugg Jeeyo*), but also headlining a web series (Netflix's *Mismatched*), lending her voice to an audio show (Marvel's *Wastelanders* and *Desi Down Under*) and getting an audience with the likes of Michelle Obama and Bill Gates. She was the only Indian YouTuber invited to the recent COP28 Climate Summit. Surely not a bad trajectory for a girl who at 11 had wanted to be a radio jockey, only to see her dream fall apart when her show was cancelled due to poor ratings.

"I'm an only child and I've grown up in a very secure, nourishing home. I've always been my biggest fan. But at that moment, I lost all confidence," recalls Prajakta. What she did have, though, is an infectious charisma, which was noticed by Sudeep Lahiri, currently the vice-president of content & strategy at One Digital Entertainment. It was Lahiri who nudged her to start a YouTube channel.

With no plan B, Prajakta, then 21, borrowed her father's camera and tripod and began recording videos at home. The first shot—only five minutes long—she recalls, had taken her hours.

The Prajakta seated at her office today is a drastically changed figure. A self-assured artist who can talk about everything from body positivity and climate change to gender equality and more, she doesn't position herself as an expert, but more as a "mediator" wanting to make an impact. She is keeping exceptionally busy too these days. A debut novel is in the pipeline, there are shows to be pitched to OTT platforms, and auditions for various roles. "I suck at compartmentalising," she says. "My parents are like, 'Please finish the book so we can have our daughter back'." ■

***-Suhani Singh***

**ACCOMPLISHMENT**

**With over 7 million followers on YouTube, Prajakta is one of the most popular digital creators in India**

**PROFESSIONAL TIP**

**"Listen to your audience if you want to stay relevant. Understand it's a long game, so surround yourself with a healthy circle"**

**↘ FAVOURITE YOUTUBER Lily a.k.a. Superwoman**

**↘ FAVOURITE CUISINE Currently, it's Korean food**

**↘ CLAIM TO FAME Prajakta's viral moment came in July 2015 with the video '10 Hilarious words Delhi people use'**